

Laser printer

The prototype of a laser printer was invented by Gary Starkweather working at Xerox in 1969. The printer was built by modifying one of the Xerox copiers

Languages etc.

Facebook has launched the Swahili version of their social networking site. This move was done to target the 110 million and above Swahili speaking people so that Facebook can increase its userbase

Photo printer test

Compact Photo Printers

There are many people who sometimes just need to see their photographs printed out immediately, wherever they might be. To that end, the new trend in photo printers is the compact photo printer, that can be carried anywhere and print mainly 4 x 6 photos – also called as 4R size. We tested two such compact photo printers; the Epson PictureMate PM 215 and Canon Selphy CP 760.

Canon Selphy CP 760

The entire range of Selphy products from Canon are compact photo printers and the one we received was the Canon Selphy CP 760. This Selphy is really compact, smaller than the Epson compact printer and also lighter, weighing in at around 950 grams. The CP 760 comes with a 2.5-inch display located on top. This display can't be tilted or rotated, but it already has been positioned at a slight angle which indicates a well thought out design from Canon. The buttons of the printer are located just below the display. There are two USB ports on the left side of the printer, one to connect to the PC and the other for PictBridge connectivity.

The Canon Selphy CP 760 uses a single ink cassette which is very different from that which the Epson PM 215 uses. This ink cassette is loaded into the printer from the right side; this is pretty easy, as it just needs to be pushed in and once you hear the click, you are all set.

The Selphy CP 760 also supports direct printing from memory cards, slots for which are located at the front side of the printer. This printer works with detachable paper cassettes that correspond to specific paper sizes. These will have to be carried separately, if you intend to use this printer on the go.

The paper cassette provided only prints postcard 4R size, which we found is slightly different from the regular 4 x 6 photo paper. Canon does

provide a few sheets of paper so that you can try printing on postcards directly. There are no separate trays for in and out, the single paper cassette functions as both.

This Canon Selphy CP 760 prints in a very different manner with the ink cassette that was mentioned earlier; it prints in layers. Once the print command is given, the paper goes in and only a layer of yellow is printed, with all the yellows present in the image and this is followed by magenta, then cyan and lastly an overcoat is printed that keeps the print safe from water spills and finger prints, generally supposed to give prints a longer lifetime. This is known as dye sublimation.

The quality of the prints was exceptional – the first test image showed the overall tone to be slightly on the yellow side, but the detail that was printed was just perfect. Each and every tiny detail could be seen under the magnifying glass and that too with these relatively small 4 x 6 prints. Even so, the darker shades of black merged together in the greyscale chart. The second test image was spot on – it was just perfect. The third test image showed the same yellowish tone, but again the detail was brilliant. The only place where the Selphy CP 760 was not able to output a great quality print was with the Combi document – the images were printed out stunningly, but the text was bad. It was not smooth at all, and the ink did not spread evenly on all characters. Each character had different shades of green and black which made some

areas dark and others light; basically unreadable. The yellow text on a black background was equally bad and unreadable. Text is not this Selphy's strong point, but if you give it images, it will just produce them with ease.

Priced at Rs. 5,495 this makes a great buy, with the only exception that you will need to replace the ink cassette after every 36 prints. Canon sells postcard packs with a combination of 108 sheets of postcard size paper and three ink cassettes – this will cost you around Rs. 1,250, which is still a good deal for the quality that this printer delivers.

Epson PictureMate PM 215

The shape, size and weight of the Epson PictureMate PM 215 is very different from the Canon Selphy CP 760. It is larger and also much heavier, with a weight of about 2.2 kgs. The PictureMate PM 215 looks like a small square plastic bucket or picnic basket that you would take to the beach, and it even has a nice handle so it can be carried anywhere conveniently.

The PM 215 has a 2.5-inch display which is covered by a turquoise coloured lid. The lid also has a dark-tinted window right above the display, so you can have a quick look without even opening it up. When you lift the lid, the display and the buttons of this printer are exposed. The display, by default, is flat, but can be tilted to adjust the angle. The paper feeder is located just behind the display. The paper-out tray is revealed by a simple push at the front, which then reveals the tray. Memory card reader slots are also present behind this tray and the direct print button is together with all the other buttons. The power adapter is connected at the rear of the printer, where you also find the USB ports to connect the PM 215 to a PC or to a camera.



Canon Selphy CP 760

Similarly to the Canon Selphy CP 760, the Epson PictureMate PM 215 also comes with a single cartridge called an Epson Photo Cartridge which has to be loaded from the rear of the printer. If the cartridge is not installed, the PM 215 displays an error message and also gives instructions on how to install the cartridge.

The Epson PM 215 was the fastest printer to deliver prints at maximum quality as it took just 47.1 seconds. The colour reproduction with this printer was quite accurate, but there was loss of detail. With the first test image, the scene with the water was good and accurate with little loss of details. In the greyscale chart, the last two shades of black were merged together and in the sharpness zone, there was some jagged lines reproduced towards the end. With the second test image, the entire image looked balanced, even though there was supposed to be more of a green tone to the image; also the colours at the base of the image were too fluorescent. The third test image was also well-balanced and had black reproduced correctly. Even so, there were details missing in some parts of the test image, such as the dimples in the golf ball and some textures. The Combi document was much better than that produced by the Canon Selphy CP 760, and the text was also reproduced smoothly. The red cherries looked great and were well differentiated. The only place where this printer was lacking was with the yellow text on the black background; here it showed a similar outcome to the Selphy CP 760.

The Epson PictureMate PM 215 is priced at Rs. 9,999, which is slightly high, but you get overall well-balanced colours.

Epson
PictureMate
PM 215

